With the reckless bravado of his dash across the Ravi, Akbar took a risky shortcut through a forest in which several of his already small troop of soldiers got lost. Near Manikpur, where they needed to cross the Ganga, Akbar would not wait to build a bridge but drove his elephant into the river, swollen with the rains that had just begun. Abul Fazl reports that only eleven commanders came with him – among them Aziz, his milk brother, and Darbar Khan, the dastango – and Nizamuddin records that over 1000 foot soldiers swam alongside. Thus, the air resounding with the splashing of his men and the 'raging and roaring' of his elephants – Balsundar, Khudabaksh, Tufan Masti – Akbar forded the river and camped for the night.[80]

As he would do again and again throughout his life, Akbar had taken his foe by surprise. Ali Quli and Bahadur were less than 10 kilometres away, but utterly ignorant of the padishah's presence. They were having a wild night of it, in fact, with dancers to entertain them and plenty to drink.

'O all ye doomed ones . . .!'[81]

A voice in the dark called out to the brothers. Akbar was nearby, the voice went on; but the brothers paid no heed. That informer, as Abul Fazl tells it, belonged to an 'ignorant loyalist' of Akbar's, hoping to prevent a confrontation between the Uzbek brothers and the padishah's relatively smaller force. Perhaps it was one of Munim Khan's men, commissioned by Munim[82] to make one last effort to help his obstinate Uzbek friend.

Whoever he was, he failed. Ali Quli was not the kind of man to retreat from a battle. Besides, a man who could finish a game of chess while battle raged was not to be put off his drink by disembodied voices. The revelry continued, for tomorrow is always another day, even if, in this case, it was to be the last day of Ali Quli's life.

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On 9 June 1567, Akbar climbed upon Balsundar and, with Aziz sharing his howdah, marched upon the Uzbeks.

Ali Quli was sleeping off the night's carousal when Akbar's army arrived. Unruffled, the Uzbek got on his horse and rode into Akbar's vanguard. It was not a propitious start: in the chaos of the fight, Ali Quli's turban fell off. 'At the sight,' writes Badauni, Ali Quli's brother, Bahadur – the man who